he were covering up for his Cuban friends. Mikoyan called in General Gribkov and, in Pliev's presence, dressed him down for failing to report the incident to him. As Gribkov later recalled, Mikoyan "strictly reminded everyone, and me in the first instance, that he was representing the Central Committee of the CPSU there and had to know who was reporting what to Moscow." Mikoyan wanted to be the only channel of information between Moscow and Cuba.[16]

The Cubans were not the only ones to misbehave on October Revolution Day. Soviet officers and men caused trouble in a different way. On November 7, Private Veselovsky of the 181st Missile Regiment, posted at Los Palacios (San Cristóbal area), opened fire at a military patrol. Luckily, no one was killed or wounded, and the whole episode was covered up. The drunken soldier, a candidate member of the Communist Party, was denied the right to join it but never faced criminal charges. They would have reflected badly on his commanders as well.[17]

The news about the withdrawal caused a great deal of confusion and worsened the already low morale among the Soviet troops, who had first been ordered to construct the launch sites and then to dismantle or even destroy them. "Why did they send us to Cuba? Why take this equipment here and back?" Private Stoianov, who left Cuba on the *Metallurg Anosov*, asked his fellow soldiers. When his comrade Cherny tried to calm him down, saying, "If we hadn't come here, perhaps none of us would be alive today, as there could have been a thermonuclear war," Stoianov was anything but convinced. Not only was morale sinking, but the ideological indoctrination was in jeopardy.

The officers and men were leaving their Cuban posts without the expected thanks from the locals. "The procedure of withdrawal from Cuba inflicted a deep wound on the souls of our warriors," recalled Rafael Zakirov, the commander of the group handling the tactical nuclear warheads. "It was done in secret, and the vehicles were loaded at night, without the usual leave-taking of the Cuban comrades: the ships departed from empty docks. We left Cuba just as if we had been guilty of something, although everyone had honorably and selflessly done his martial duty and carried out the Motherland's command." Those who had a chance to say goodbye to their Cuban friends and acquaintances were also leaving sick at